

Elia Gasparolo – Relics of Peace

Years ago, I wrote about Elia Gasparolo's work. At that time, I highlighted that "life, ourselves, things—everything seems to be a handful of more or less well-organized fragments that allow us to construct understandable readings of the immeasurable. However, eternity manifests itself in each one of them forever, leaving a trace of our passage; art is the materialization and evidence of our fleeting existence." I quote my own words because I could not express it better now when faced with a body of work that sustains the persistent search for beauty in the interstices, in the silenced spaces, in what is discarded because it "doesn't fit," in that handful of fragments.

By definition, relics are remains. Those remains—depending on religious conventions—can be of all kinds and materials: from personal belongings and objects associated with a sanctified person to their own physical remains. But beyond cultural variations, what all relics undoubtedly share is a kind of aura that surrounds them, elevating them above the earthly plane. From that divine, spiritual realm—beyond the one we humans inhabit—people seek to preserve, through the safeguarding of these remains, what still lingers of that intangible world. And they venerate them, protect them, respect them, and listen to their story again and again, seeking in them support, miracles, companionship, and comfort.

Elia Gasparolo's relics are an ode to the beauty inherent in error, in what we leave aside, in what supposedly does not work. The fabrics preserved inside her wooden reliquaries, protected by glass, are small textiles of extraordinary delicacy. Each one, composed of fibers arranged in what appears to be a disordered weave, reveals the work of the silkworms that performed their task "so poorly" that they left their lives within it. In twelve days, silkworms empty themselves, giving all the silk they carry in order to create enough protection to transform into butterflies. Yet life often proposes an alternative plan, and those little creatures that fail to wrap themselves in their cocoons—because they could not build them, because they were not ready, because they did not know how—are condemned. But they leave behind their tangled silk as testimony of their presence, of their attempt, until the very last moment, to survive. And Elia recovers those fragments, transforming the silkworms' failure into a source of inspiration: she turns them into relics, ennobling the legacy of their struggle—a peaceful struggle.

Lic. María Carolina Baulo, April 2023